position and No. 11 Platoon of Delta Company under Subedar Joginder Singh Sahnan occupied it. The remaining two platoons of Delta Company dug themselves in at Tongpeng-la, three kilometres behind the IB Ridge position. Bravo Company was in the area known as Pamdir with No. 6 Platoon at Samatso. The rest of the battalion under the command of Lieutenant Colonel B. N. Mehta was in defences around Milakteng-la, which was roughly halfway between Bum-la and Tawang, where they were further reinforced by one company of 4 Garhwal Rifles.

The Battalion HQ of 4 Garhwal Rifles was set up in Tawang itself, so it could coordinate with its two companies deployed at Mukdang-la (also known as Landa) and Penkingtang, with a platoon at Geyshe-la. 97 Field Battery with its complement of eight 25-pounders was deployed at the road head to Bum-la while the 7 Bengal Mountain Battery with its mules was deployed in the Milakteng-la area. The troop of 116 Heavy Mortar Battery had deployed on the Sulla-Samatso track.

After the Chinese attack on 20 October, activity across Bum-la started in real earnest. From the Indian observation posts, the Chinese could be seen openly occupying their assembly areas. So cocky were the Chinese of their numerical superiority, they even held morning PT for their soldiers right under the noses of the Indians. The frustration among young artillery officers who were raring to have a crack at the Chinese was evident from Second Lieutenant Darshan Khullar's comment: 'If only our artillery had engaged them, they could have been killed in their hundreds. Orders for opening fire had to come down from the highest authority, in this case HQ Eastern Command, whose intention was not to provoke the Chinese.'

The Chinese on their part were obviously patiently waiting for their column that was coming down the Khenzemane-Zimithang-Lumla route. Niranjan Prasad had finally uprooted himself from Zimithang and made the long trek back to Tawang with the Chinese following closely. To complete the farce that was being enacted at the higher levels of command, he received a message over the wireless appointing him acting IV Corps Commander while he and Brigadier Kalyan Singh were somewhere near Lum-la. But by this time, the general neither had any staff nor any means of communicating with anybody. They finally got to Tawang on the evening of 22 October where they found the Eastern Army Commander. Officers present recall that there was a sharp exchange of words between Niranjan Prasad and Bogey Sen. Sen accused GOC 4 Division of cowardice and